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Jack Palmer

Trumpeter Jack Palmer has seen it all in the music business. A native of Rome, New York, he was initiated into entertainment in the thriving music scene at Sylvan Beach, New York in the mid-1930s. He paid his musical dues in New York City and found work with jazz greats Red Norvo, Miff Mole and Bunny Berigan. Jack was an important port of the Harry James Orchestra and roommate of an up-and-coming singer named Frank Sinatra. He performed on television and records with The Jackie Gleason Orchestra and his versatility enabled him to function in a wide variety of musical settings throughout his career. Of the numerous top flight musicians to come out of Central New York, no one is more respected and admired than Jack Palmer.

Jack was interviewed at Hamilton College on September 24, 1997 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive. Jack's son, drummer Jack Palmer Jr., was also present during the interview.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're filming today at Hamilton College for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm very happy to have my personal friend and veteran musician Jack Palmer from Rome, New York. Welcome to Hamilton.

JP: Oh, thank you very much for the nice introduction.

MR: Well I practiced a lot on that one, because I've been looking forward to this time when we could do this.

JP: Well thank you.

MR: And it was interesting that you were just looking at the other folks we've interviewed and a lot of them were your personal friends.

JP: Oh, yeah. Yes I was surprised at all you had there.

MR: The Swing Era of music was quite a time for music in the United States.

JP: The what?

MR: The Swing Era.

JP: Oh, dear, yeah. A great era. A beautiful era.

MR: Well when you were a young boy, did you grow up in Rome, New York?

JP: Yeah.

MR: Even before you started the trumpet, can you recall what kind of music you were hearing as a child?

JP: No I couldn't say off hand. Because my father brought home a trumpet when I was thirteen years old. So really just before that all I knew was singing in school, you know, school songs. But I liked music then. I didn't care about singing that much, but you know, you joined in class vocals.

MR: Did you take trumpet lessons in school?

JP: No, my father brought me to Professor Chambroka who was with the Rome White Band Hall which is opposite Second Street if you know Rome. It's still there, the hall where I took my first lesson. Prof Chambroka was a graduate of Milan Conservatory in Italy, and was an excellent teacher, but he just taught music. He wasn't a trumpet teacher. He taught music. He was a clarinet player originally himself. So he taught great clarinet. He brought up some great clarinet players there.

MR: Was he pretty strict?

JP: I beg your pardon?

MR: Was he pretty strict?

JP: He was a nice guy but he was very firm I would say, rather than strict. The difference is just so slight. Yeah, he was firm. He was respected.

MR: So you took to the trumpet pretty quickly, it became your instrument.

JP: Oh yeah. Yeah I took to it. And Mrs. Vanderpool was a teacher in the Thomas Street School. I had to go to Thomas Street School. And I think that was where I had my first school band experience. I was thirteen years old. Yeah, I took lessons from Chambroka , like I said it's opposite Second Street in Rome. The building is still there, all by itself, right on the railroad tracks.

MR: So you played trumpet all the way through high school?

JP: Um hum.

MR: When was the first time that you started to get out and play for money?

JP: Well I was playing in Sylvan Beach and there was a colored band there and the wife of the trumpet player chased him right into Oneida Lake.

MR: She chased him into Oneida Lake?

JP: Yeah. He was fooling around with another woman or something like that whatever it was. Anyway so there was an opening for me.

MR: How lucky for you.

JP: And anyway so they needed a trumpet player and I was just across the street, like across the alleyway from there and just fooling around, and somebody come over and says, "Do you want to play?" And I says, "Yeah." So it was Shore Lake or East Lake, it was a lake of some kind, the name of the building. And it was a colored band. And they just faked, no music. So I was lucky enough to know the songs that they were playing. Of course they asked, do you know such and such and I happened to have a fair repertoire because all we did in Rome then was what was cool then, not where we read music. We read music with Chambroka in the Rome White band and in school then. But outside of that we just, whenever we got together, young boys and everything, we faked, we just played songs that we knew and tried to make them sound good.

MR: Who were you listening to on the records at that time?

JP: Duke Ellington and oh I used to stay up until twelve o'clock midnight to listen to Cab Calloway. I liked the way he sang, you know, he was a shouter. But the band was excellent. The band was excellent. From the Cotton Club up in Harlem. And Duke Ellington of course we would listen to. It seemed at the time that the most popular bands were the colored bands for some reason or other. The white bands weren't that popular, outside of Paul Whiteman we'll say, who was a big name anyway, and Ben Bernie who was on the radio, but this was before television.

MR: They were more on the sweet side of music rather than the jazz?

JP: Yeah. They weren't jazz bands. The jazz band at that time was Duke Ellington and Jimmy Lunceford. That's all I recall right off hand.

MR: So do you remember how old you were when you had this first experience in Sylvan Beach with this band?

JP: I would say seventeen — sixteen, seventeen. I must have been seventeen otherwise my mother wouldn't have allowed me to be in Sylvan Beach I guess you know.

MR: So you came home and said: guess what I did, I played with this band.

JP: Yeah.

MR: Well how did they feel about that?

JP: Well my father loved music and he was for me a hundred percent or whatever. Long as I didn't drink or get smashed or anything. At that time anyway, there wasn't any booze around, like it was all hidden, you know, what'd they say —

MR: Oh, this was during prohibition?

JP: Yeah, sure. Because then when the law was passed it was wide open, it was great. So this band from Syracuse was working in Sylvan Beach also, so they come over and they heard me because I played like colored people, you know, I played black style you know what I mean? And so they asked me to come to Syracuse. So I said, "Well you've got to ask my mother." Well I couldn't leave home, you know? So I introduced them, they came to my house, and they said they wanted me in Syracuse so my mother let me go. And they got me a room in Syracuse, and after everything was all over, we were playing, we stopped somewhere and had coffee, you know like that style, and then they drove me to the room where I had the room, now all of a sudden I'm all alone, you know what I mean? Everybody's going to their homes and everything but I'm in a room, first time I'm away from my family, and boy I went to bed, but in about an hour I got up and I was hitchhiking back to Rome.

MR: No kidding. Got homesick, huh?

JP: I didn't know what, like to be outside of my house? That was very, ummm. So that I remember very vividly.

MR: That's very interesting.

JP: My mother said, "What are you doing home?" Not what are you doing, like what happened? Here it is like three or four o'clock in the morning. She says, "You sick?" I said no, no, I'm all right, I just was homesick I told her, and I started crying, believe me.

MR: Well you much have had a good home experience to make you want to come back.

JP: Oh, yeah, oh gee, yeah. I was the oldest in the family and it was myself and then three sisters then another brother, then another sister. We were a very close family. A lot of love in the family.

MR: Well after that first experience away from home —

JP: Oh, homesick.

MR: You must have gotten over that.

JP: Oh, yeah.

MR: Because you went on to play with some great people.

JP: Then I stayed in Syracuse a while, and the piano player got a job where Colgate University is, what's that place?

MR: Yeah, down in—

JP: Ithaca.

MR: Well Cornell is in Ithaca.

JP: Cornell. Well it was Ithaca. And I was going with my wife then but we weren't married, we were going together, so she had a family, relatives in Syracuse. I was in Ithaca, she went to Syracuse to visit her family so that we could see each other. So then we figured that wasn't enough so we got married in Ithaca. That was it.

MR: And how old were you then?

JP: I would say twenty. So we got married there in Ithaca, and I forgot where we went from Ithaca. We came back home. She went to her house, which was in Taberg on a farm, and I went to my house, and then I finally told my mother and she finally told her family. So then I got a job in Saranac Lake quickly so that we didn't have to stay at our homes or get a household together. So we went to Saranac Lake and I played there at the Overlook Inn, oh for about a year. So then a girl singer, Jerry Kruger, she got interested in me and my playing and so forth. She was a good singer. So she moved around pretty good and she was a mover, she talked and quacked. So she got me to come to Newark. But she got me a job in Elizabeth, New Jersey, and that's where he was born, Jackie was born, my son. And I was working a Chinese restaurant. We had a noon session and a supper session. And that was a Chinese restaurant. I'm trying to think of the name. Anyway from there this girl got me a job in Newark at the Club Miami, as the band leader. So I had a rehearsal with the acts, and the guy that showed up last was Jackie Gleason. So that was 1936. That's when I first met him.

MR: So when you say you were rehearsing with the acts—

JP: I beg your pardon?

MR: You were rehearsing with the acts that came in, you had to provide different kinds of music for whether it was a dance routine or a comedic —.

JP: Whatever music they had. They had their own charts, and if they didn't have a chart of something they wanted, they'd say, "I'm used to playing 'Tea for Two'" for instance, and I'd do a chorus and a half of this or whatever, whatever. I sing a chorus and dance a chorus and then whatever. And so we'd rehearse and then we'd do the show at night. And I was pretty well liked I guess, it seemed anyway, because I was doing pretty good at it, and the acts — word got around in New York. They got a good band over in Newark. So the acts that came there knew of me already somehow or other. They said we heard— Because the band they had before was a good band, a black band, a great band, but they couldn't read very good you know, but they were great. And once they got into the charts though, you know they played without the music afterwards. They were great. Fat Jenkins I remember was the trumpet player. Isn't this funny — that many years ago and I remember his name? Wow.

MR: Well those acts probably appreciated when they could come in and give you the music.

JP: Yeah. And we'd rehearse them. Yeah we could read. I had a good piano player, especially like for singers that wanted a little ad lib just piano you know, and then we'd come in on the second chorus with the full band. It was great. It was a great experience. And Gleason was — the boss, George Sosson, that was his name, was a heck of a nice guy and he used have master of ceremonies. He used to go into New York and get acts. It was all usually a dance team, a girl singer, and an emcee — a master of ceremonies. But when he got ahold of Gleason for some reason or other Gleason stayed there, a year or two years. He took a liking to Gleason, then he'd take him to different places. The boss's wife was a shorthander and she'd write down the jokes of other emcees. But he usually used to rehearse and then wind up doing his own act. Like he just fell into his own routines which he liked doing.

MR: So he did stand up comedy.

JP: Gleason?

MR: Yeah.

JP: Oh, yeah, yeah. And he was a natural funny guy anyway. Because like after the gig we always used to go to Stark's Restaurant in Newark in town. He and I and Tony Amico who was the head waiter. It was the band leader, the head waiter and the comic. And the three of us were very, very friendly. And we'd go into town to Stark's Restaurant and have morning breakfast like, and then come back and go to our rooms. Beautiful memories, beautiful.

MR: This music you were playing, when did you first get into what you would call a jazz band?

JP: Well I always leaned towards playing jazz you know. I mean that was in Rome before I even went out. Because when I played with this black band in Sylvan Beach, that was without music. We played songs, and then we'd play what they call the blues you know, which was a traditional, three chord changes and so forth. St. Louis Blues was a standard and then we'd take off on it you know. Go ahead, ask me questions. I don't want to talk too much.

MR: No, that's okay. After this experience with this pit band and so forth, then you got into, you started to do some recording fairly soon after that? Who was the first, was it Miff Mole or was that later on? Who was the first band that you got to do some recording with?

JP: Well let's see. I went into New York so I transferred in so you had to — when you transferred in, I'll make this real short — you're not allowed to work a steady job for the first three months. Otherwise everybody'd come to New York you know what I mean? But they made it difficult. After three months then you could accept a steady job, with permission. And after that three months was over, now came time to get your union card, and you had to have a hundred dollars to pay for the union card. So then I became a member. It seemed like as soon as I got my card, George Wettling, the drummer, he heard me somewhere, I can't think right where, but he says come down to such and such a studio. I went there and it was Red Norvo and Mildred Bailey. And I sat in and first thing you know, I didn't know it was being recorded. We were making a record. This was the first record date I ever had. And I didn't know, I never was acquainted with that stuff. And I said gee, I'm making a record. And I remember the tune, because I had a sixteen bar solo in the front, in a harmon mute, called "I Used to be Colorblind." That was the name of it. And then we played "Just You Just Me," which was a standard, and I had the opening, after the introduction I had the opening sixteen bars there, and then eight bars in the last chorus in the middle, the release. And all of a sudden I'm recording jazz, which I never had except on home stuff, home recording.

MR: Did that record come out?

JP: "Just You Just Me," yeah.

MR: Do you have a copy?

JP: No.

MR: Oh, love to find one.

JP: I lost all my records, all the personal records that I had, the collection that I had, everything. Anyway.

MR: What was, the recording at that time, probably consisted of one microphone or something?

JP: Yeah. I had to leave my chair, because I played in a harmon mute with the stem pulled out, and I had to walk — so they left me eight bars out of the brass section to give me time to walk to the microphone, you know what I mean? And so I played into the mic and then I had to walk back and I had eight bars open to walk back and then take the mute out and join the section. Eddie Sauter was our first arranger with Red Norvo and Mildred Bailey. And before me he had played third trumpet in the band, like before the band became pretty well known.

MR: So you had decided by this time that I'm a musician and this is what I'm doing for the rest of my life?

JP: Oh yeah, no, I was being a professional, I thought I was a professional, and then I saw Jerry Jerome, I don't know if you recall that name.

MR: Sure do.

JP: Tenor saxophone player. I was going into the subway of Jackson Heights, to go into town, and he was coming out of it. And he says, "Hey Jackson, where you going?" I says, "I'm going in town" you know, "and see what's happening at the Nola studios." He says, "Harry James is starting — you know Harry from Benny Goodman's band?" I says, "Well I don't know him personally." He says, "He's rehearsing his first band." He says, "Go to the Nola Studios and tell them I suggested you talk to him." See and I did. I went there and to make a long story short, I waited until they took a break and I went up to Harry and I says, "Jerry Jerome suggested I talk to you, Harry." He says, "I know you, Jack Palmer from Red Norvo's band." He says, "I saw you at the Famous Door." I says, "Yeah." He says, "You don't want to join my band" he says, "you'll never get a chance to play," he says you know, and he says, "because I know you like to play jazz." I says, "I don't care." I says, "I like to hear you" and I says, "so I don't mind not playing. I'd love to be with the band." And it was an excellent band.

MR: Now I'm looking at a sheet from a big band book, from 1938, and it has Red Norvo and it has you listed with Johnny Owens—

JP: Yeah.

MR: And Barney Zudekoff—

JP: Barney Zudekoff.

MR: And you have an "H" after your name.

JP: A what?

MR: An "H."

JP: Hot.

MR: Hot. Hot trumpet. You were the hot man.

JP: Yeah. Now Barney Zudekoff, his brother was Moe Zudekoff, trombone player. Buddy Morrow, his name was Moe Zudekoff, Buddy Morrow. Okay.

MR: Okay. So it wasn't just the rock & roll guys who changed their names. So you went from Red Norvo, you were the hot chair, right? You were the guy that took the rides?

JP: Yeah.

MR: And you—

JP: Second trumpet chair was always the ride chair. First trumpet just played first trumpet that's what he did. Third trumpet player played third, and occasional easy first parts, so that the first trumpet player could take a break on the third part.

MR: So you went with Harry James then.

JP: From Red Norvo, yeah. Well, like Jerry Jerome said, "Harry James is having a rehearsal, so go up there," which I did. And he says, "You got your trumpet with you?" I says, "Yeah." I always went in town with the horn you know. And he says, "All right, after we take a break" he says, "you want to play, you want to sit in?" I says, "Yeah." So I did. And after that he called me aside and he said, "Are you interested in joining the band?" and so forth. And I said, "Yeah, I'd love to." So that was 1939, the year.

MR: Can I ask you what he was paying?

JP: No, you could ask me. Because before that I was getting eighty-five dollars a week with Red Norvo.

MR: That's not too bad for the time.

JP: 1938. It was great. So I went with Harry for the same money, like I don't know. I guess eighty-five was the standard thing then. If you got a hundred that means you were a little special you know. Yeah. First trumpet player got a hundred. Second trumpet player got eighty-five.

MR: So what kind of schedule did the Harry James band have when they first started out? I mean did you go right into like really on the road type stuff?

JP: We went right to the Benjamin Franklin Hotel in Philadelphia. That was the first appearance. And from there we just did a gang of one nighters, you know, one night stands. And we came back to New York to The Roseland Ballroom and let's see I started in January, and Frank Sinatra joined us in May. And I remember Harry said, Harry told me about him somewhere along the way, when we were at the Paramount Theatre. He says, "Jack you want to take a ride with me after the last show? I'm going to go see, there's a kid playing a singing act in New Jersey somewhere" he says, "and I'm going to go catch him." And, "Do you want to come with me?" And I says, "I can't, I've got people from Rome visiting me and I promised to take them to Chinatown." So he went, anyway, he took Louise Tobin, his wife. The next morning, after the first show, and just before the second show, evidently Frank had been up in the dressing room, and he came

downstairs before we went into the pit, and Harry introduced him, and they had already signed a contract. Harry says, "Fellas, I want you to meet our new vocalist, Frank Sinatra, and we'll meet him singly afterwards" you know because we had to go into the pit. And so from that engagement, the next engagement was New Haven, Connecticut and that's where Frank joined us and Harry introduced him there, and said, "Ladies and gentlemen I'd like to introduce you to our — have you meet our new vocalist, who we don't have any arrangements for—come on out Frank and say hello to the folks." And Frank did. Then Harry says "well why don't you sing something Frank, anyway." So Frank leaned over to the piano player and says I guess what key he was going to sing. And Harry says, "What are you going to sing, Frank," and he says, "Stardust." I never forgot that, that was his first song, without any music, it was just the piano and the rhythm section you know?

MR: That's a tough song to open up to.

JP: Yeah. But that's the one he chose and he sang it. I'll never forget that. Because we thought why did he choose "Stardust" you know, which really was an instrumental more than it was a vocal.

MR: Wow. Was he a skinny little kid then?

JP: Oh, yeah. Yeah, he was skinnier than the microphone. He was good though. Right away you could tell he knew how to use his hands. Because in New Jersey he used to work on the floor, you know what I mean? So he knew how to carry himself and everything. Dick Haymes didn't know. Dick Haymes stood in front of the microphone like a poker. Because Dick followed Frank. Because Dick's mother was a vocal teacher. But Dick was, gee I remember when he joined the band he was just like a — but out came this beautiful voice see? And then little by little he started loosening up and using his hands.

MR: Well when you say Frank worked on the floor, he was interacting more with the audience right up close in New Jersey?

JP: In New Jersey he was in a floor show you know what I mean?

MR: Okay, yeah.

JP: So in other words they probably had a dance team and there usually was a dance team and a vocalist and something else, I can't remember what. Usually it was three acts. Acrobat dancer, dance team and a singer. That was it. That was the general run. I know that they used to get that from New York, always three acts, three acts.

MR: What was his level of — was he confident with himself when he first started with you guys?

JP: Frank? Oh yeah. Right from the beginning, yeah. He was confident all right. He wasn't cocky like some people would think so. He was just very sure of himself. Very confident, and he knew how to use his hands. Because like I say, he'd been out on the floor, you know what I mean?

MR: He was a showman?

JP: Yeah. He had to be. Whereas most singers they just knew a microphone, that's all, they played to the mic you know what I mean?

MR: You know one thing I'm curious about, when you see bands now we're used to lots of sound equipment. What kind of sound equipment did they have back then for the vocalist?

JP: Oh, just a microphone and speakers.

MR: A couple little speakers?

JP: Two speakers that's all. One on each end of the bandstand.

MR: So it was the band's job to be aware of how loud they could play to accommodate the singer?

JP: No. We played our standard volume. I mean we played soft, loud, whatever, however the music was marked. Because the arranger usually wrote down where he wanted piano, double piano, soft, loud, f, double f and so forth. Swing. Like the last choruses were always the going out choruses. Music was well marked.

MR: And the engagements you were playing mostly at that time, were they dances? Mostly dances?

JP: Oh, yeah. It was a dance band. That's what they called dance bands. It was 1938 was Red Norvo and Mildred Bailey, and 1939 was Harry James.

MR: Did you end up being — I heard you were roommates with Frank Sinatra for a while.

JP: Yeah, in Harry's band. Well because I sent my wife home because we were going on the road, so I sent Molly home with little Jackie, and so I was the only one who didn't have a roommate then see? So Frank says, "Well can I room with you?" I says, "Yeah, okay." So that's how that happened to be.

MR: What was he like as a roommate?

JP: I didn't love him. No. We were very compatible, Frank and I. Incidentally we were the only two Italians in the band. We never thought about language, color, Italian, who was black, white. In music bands then, nobody thought about anything as far as nationalities or color or anything, you cared about how they played. That was most important.

MR: On that subject, what was the first band that you ever played with that was integrated with black and white players?

JP: Well like I say in Sylvan Beach —

MR: Sylvan Beach, that's right I forgot.

JP: In Sylvan Beach that was a colored band. Although there wasn't any white guys in the band, I was the first one. But really you know you never thought about it. You never thought about who was black, white, Chinese or what. Because musicians, you cared how a guy played. That was the guiding rule or whatever. How well does he play, that's all.

MR: That's wonderful to hear.

JP: Yeah. It didn't matter, black, white, Chinese or what. How did he play. Did he play jazz? Was he a straight player? Did he have a good sound?

MR: Well you're listed in this picture with the Harry James band from 1939, in addition to trumpet, as a singer also.

JP: Well I used to do what they call scat singing.

MR: You were the scatter, huh?

JP: Scat vocals. I sang the songs that Frank didn't want to sing. No they were the rhythm songs really.

MR: The jump tunes?

JP: The jump tunes, yeah, where you didn't sing ballad style you know. So that's what I sang.

MR: Like give me an example of one of the jump tunes you might have sung.

JP: Gee, I couldn't off hand, really. I can't really.

MR: Kind of like "Sunny Side of the Street?"

[off camera Jack's son talking]

JP: I can't even remember how that goes — "Sunny Side of the Street." [sings] Get your hat/get your coat/leave your worries on your doorstep/life is oh so sweet/on the sunny side of the street. Get your hat, your cane, your coat, your gloves/leave your worries on your doorstep baby.

MR: There you go.

JP: Something like that style.

MR: Would Harry James call those tunes out when the crowd was really getting — was he working the crowd kind of?

JP: Yeah. We didn't know what went on in his mind. We just, whatever he called out we took out tunes and sometimes we just, I would know like what followed, his general pattern, so sometimes I'd just have it stuck up so I could reach it quickly you know.

MR: So was there any rivalry between Harry James and Frank Sinatra as far as who was the star here?

JP: Oh, no. Because, no. We were in the Paramount Theatre like I said, and Harry says, "Jack do you want to come with me tonight, I'm going to New Jersey. Remember I told you about that kid singer?" And I said, "I can't go, I've got people from Rome." But he went that night with Louise, his wife. And the next morning Frank was at the theatre. And then he joined us in New Haven Connecticut like I say. And he didn't have any tunes and Harry introduced him, and he went out and he sang "Stardust."

MR: So Frank was always, he knew that Harry was the boss.

JP: He what?

MR: He knew that Harry was the boss, is that right? That Harry James was the boss?

JP: Oh, Harry was the leader. That was his boss, yes.

MR: Was he a good guy to work for?

JP: Who Harry?

MR: Harry.

JP: Yeah, great. Yeah he was a gentleman.

MR: And eventually Frank went with Tommy Dorsey?

JP: Yeah. Yeah Harry was a little disturbed about it. But Tommy offered him more money, that was the point. The point was money. And then Tommy was already an established band. And Frank felt that where Harry's band was a new band, a baby band we used to call it. So Frank thought that was a big move for him, great, which it was at the time, to go with Tommy Dorsey, a big name, already established. Jo Stafford, and the Pied Pipers, was that it?

MR: The Pied Pipers, yeah. So when you were with Harry, for a couple of years?

JP: Yeah. About a year and a half.

MR: Did you start to want to get more solo space or were you happy just to—

JP: Well I enjoyed listening to Harry so much, I admired him so much, I was happy to be in that band, because I learned a lot in that band. Because Harry said, he said, "Jack I know you played with Red Norvo you played solos" you know. And I said, "Yeah but that's all right, don't mind." He says he thought I wouldn't be happy, you know, not playing. But still and all at the end, when we got on location, when we got on location, at the end of the night like he'd take off maybe the last half hour, and I would play. We had some different songs that had trumpet solos, and not his solos, but trumpet solos where I would take off on.

MR: Did you ever get involved on any of those band movies? Those short movies they did?

JP: Yeah. I made one with Teddy Powell. I think the name, yes, I remember the name, "Jam Session." It was a lot of bands. And I was with Teddy Powell. And I come out and I did a vocal I think, I'm not sure anymore. Yeah, Teddy Powell's band.

MR: We should get a copy of that.

JP: The name of it is "Jam Session."

MR: Okay, we'll look for it.

JP: That's the name of the movie short or whatever, the band movie anyway.

[off camera Jack's son talking]

JP: Well it's probably around, you'll have to search I guess you know.

MR: So eighty-five dollars a week you were getting. Was that enough to live on and send some home to support your son?

JP: Oh, yeah, oh sure.

MR: Yeah, no problem?

JP: Oh that was big money. Gee if you got the hundred dollars, you know a dollar was a dollar then. So that fifteen dollars, to get to a hundred, wow.

MR: So what happened during the war years for you?

JP: During the war years, well I came home from California, I came back to Rome during the war years. And where'd I work Jackie, do you remember? I had to go in a defense plant. So I says if I'm going to work in a defense plant, I might as well go home instead of in California, see? So I came back to Rome and I went to work in a defense plant. That was it. And played around town here.

MR: Was there a lot of musicians in Rome that had to go in the service?

JP: Yeah.

MR: So it wasn't hard for you to find work?

JP: Well it didn't matter anyway because there weren't that many trumpet players around, there was only a couple: Tony Degrazio, and he was working burlesque in Utica; and Red Magno. There was only a couple of trumpet players, there wasn't much competition let me put it that way. They were good though, these boys.

MR: Well the war years made it hard for the big bands to keep active didn't it? With the gasoline rationing and of course a lot of them were in the service.

JP: Still the bands that were name bands we'll say, they had these camps to go to — what do you call them? You know we used to do these tours.

MR: USOs?

JP: Yeah.

MR: So they had actually built-in places to play, for the servicemen?

JP: Yeah. That was the thing. The ones that went over the best was the girl vocalists.

MR: Did musicians in the band, did they ever feel a bit resentful of the vocalists because they got the spotlight?

JP: No, no. That was part of the band in other words you know. No they never resented the vocalist. No they felt that a girl vocalist was necessary, and for them it was a respite like in other words to play background rather than be out front all the time, you know what I mean? So they enjoyed playing the background music, and especially if the girl singer was good, which most of them were.

MR: Just before we move on from the Harry James thing, what was it like traveling on the road at that time? Was it mostly trains or buses?

JP: Both. We loved the train when we could get on a train because you could stretch out and walk, walk to the other car, the dining car and so forth. And we loved the trains. Better than living in a bus. Because in a bus it got a little —

MR: A little funky, huh?

JP: That's the word I was looking for.

MR: Did you ever have any really kind of scary experiences on the road that you can recall?

JP: Gee not off hand. Everything was good.

MR: I'm glad to hear that.

JP: Yeah. Just we had to pack up at night after we got through the job, pack up and then stop at the first diner we could stop at, and then get back on the bus and go to sleep until we got to the town we were supposed to go to. And sometimes we'd get to that town too early to check in, which was eight o'clock checking in time. Maybe we got there at six o'clock. So now what do we do? Generally we went to the back of a school and in Harry's band, he loved baseball. And we had baseball equipment where the instruments were, in the rack underneath, and we got out and played ball, at six o'clock in the morning, we played ball, until eight o'clock.

MR: Then you could go to the hotel.

JP: Yeah because people were checking out and we could check in.

MR: Did your ball team ever get to play against any other bands?

JP: Oh yeah.

MR: Like who?

JP: Oh, Tommy Dorsey had a baseball team. Most of them had a baseball team.

MR: I heard Count Basie did too.

JP: Yes, yes, yes. We played up in Central Park. It was — yeah Harry, "Oh watch that equipment," you know the bats and the gloves and the balls and everything.

MR: Well it was a good distraction you know, to keep your mind active and so forth, and not just music every single day, something to do physical I guess.

JP: Well Harry naturally had the choice of positions. So he pitched for a while, and then he liked second base. Now why, I'm trying to think why. Well there was a lot of activity on second base I guess. From him to shortstop and first base I guess. But those were his two positions.

MR: Now his band, it was successful for quite a while, wasn't it?

JP: Oh, it was successful 'til unconscious.

MR: 'Til unconscious.

JP: Yeah, I mean until the end of time. I remember he became real big, and Helen Forrest, so they had a romance there for a while, Helen Forrest. Who else?

MR: What was his big tune, "Ciribiribin?"

JP: Who?

MR: "Ciribiribin." Wasn't that his tune?

JP: "Ciribiribin."

MR: Is that how you pronounce it?

JP: "Ciribiribin." [sings] That was an old standard you know, it wasn't — you know why Harry chose — why would be come out of Benny Goodman's band and choose "Ciri biri bin" which is in a circus, it's an aerial thing right? His mother was an aerialist. She used to use that as her song. And Harry James' father was the band leader, and he used to play that for his wife.

MR: While she's up on the trapeze, oh my.

JP: So Harry's father was the band leader and Harry's mother was the aerialist.

MR: Cool.

JP: We didn't know that. I found out through one night he was just reminiscing and I started pumping him, and that's how I found out about it.

MR: That's interesting.

JP: He wasn't very talkative about it.

MR: Well I don't want to jump to circuses just yet, because I know you've played in a few circuses yourself. But what happened after you left the Harry James band? I know you were with, was it —

JP: Woody Herman.

MR: Woody Herman?

JP: Yeah. That's all I remember. I was with Woody because Shorty Rogers — was that his name — trumpet player. He was in the service. So he was going to get out of the service, so his chair — Neal Hefti had his chair. But Neal Hefti was arranging and wanted to just write. But Neal played trumpet see? So he saw me, and I was in between bands, and he says, "Jack, you want to play with Woody Herman until Shorty gets out of the service?" He says, "I'm doing the chair right now and I don't want to, I've got a lot of writing to do." And I says, "Yeah." So I joined Woody Herman just for that stint.

MR: Was that "the first herd" they call it?

JP: I think so.

MR: Chubby Jackson?

JP: Yeah, Chubby, Flip Phillips—

MR: Not too shabby, that band.

JP: Tony what's his name on the piano, Chubby Jackson on bass and Davey Tough on drums.

MR: That was a good rhythm section.

JP: That was a heck of a band, yeah. Pete Candoli on trumpet, Sam Marowitz on saxophone, Flip Phillips on sax, tenor, Sam played lead. A heck of band, oh, a great band, wow.

MR: Was that band playing dances too or was it more of kind of a listening band?

JP: No, no, no. All bands played dances, because that was being a dance band, you know what I mean? We played concerts more for service areas, where we went to play for

servicemen, so then naturally it was concert time you know. But wherever there was girls and fellas, then it was usually dance time. The Palladium in California in Hollywood, wow. These were great ballrooms. The Palladium was big, wow.

MR: It's too bad that those things disappeared because I guess the dancing was so connected to the music.

JP: Well the dancing was connected to ballrooms also, see? So that's what made bands play the ballrooms, because dancing was there rather than, in some hotels, yes, big hotels would have a band like we played the Hotel Sherman — I can't think of the name of the room. Anyway, what'd I say, the Hotel Sherman? In Chicago. And the Oriental Theatre there, Chicago Theatre there. And that was our stop in Chicago, and then from there we went to California. So we did a series of one-nighters. Now my wife drove Frank Sinatra's car, because Nancy couldn't drive. So Frank's mother had given him a car to join in Harry's band. But Nancy couldn't drive. So Frank wanted the car with him. So my wife drove Nancy, and Jackie was a tot, about three, four years old, and so then he had the car in Chicago, then he had the car in California, and then he had it on the way back you know. But every time we got on location he had a car. And one time I remember he didn't pick me up, he moved. Somehow the song pluggers were after vocalists, because they needed the words to a song, you see? I wasn't important, not me alone, any musician, because we just played the music. They needed the vocalist see? The music and the words. So they romanced Frank. So they got him, like we checked in somewhere and I remember waiting for him in the lobby to go to Victor Hugo's, that's where we were going to play, and no Frank, he didn't leave me word or anything, 'till I double checked now, they says oh he checked out. Jesus was I angry. I was mad. It cost me fifteen dollars, which was a lot of money then, to get a cab to take me to Victor Hugo's or wherever we were playing. Oh I was rippin' when I —

MR: Yeah?

JP: Yeah. I didn't speak to him for two months. I didn't. I told him off and I didn't speak to him. I says, "Just stay away from me, I don't want to." And we had been roommates you know? But we got together. Because now it came time to leave California, so he started romancing me because he needed Molly, my wife, to drive his car. Nancy couldn't drive you see? He was a schemer.

MR: What kind of car was it?

JP: I think it was an Oldsmobile. I'm almost sure it was an Oldsmobile. A big car. Anyway.

MR: Well after the war years, you worked in the mill during the war years?

JP: Yeah. From California I didn't want to go to work in a factory there, I says if I'm going to work in a factory I might as well go home and be home with my folks and so forth.

Then who knew how long the war was going to last, or what was going to happen afterwards? So I said I'd rather be home so I did, I came home.

MR: Were you able to get back into music full time after World War II?

JP: Oh, well, I just packed up myself, and I went to New York. And I checked in some apartment building and then I stood on a corner with my trumpet case. Somebody came up and tapped me and said, "Want to play Saturday night? Are you working Saturday?" I said, "No."

MR: Is that right? And you didn't know this person?

JP: No. Well there were two corners to stand on. On the corner of 48th Street and Broadway, and 52nd Street and Broadway. But 52nd Street was high class musicians. 48th Street was a lower class. Well what I mean, on 52nd Street, they were in radio at the time, it wasn't television. And the guys up there did recording dates and so forth. Down here we just did saloons and — oh boy, starving days.

MR: Yeah?

JP: Oh.

MR: Paying your dues, huh? So this guy came up and hired you for a dance?

JP: Where was that?

MR: On 48th Street, you're standing on the corner.

JP: Oh, yeah.

MR: And this guy comes up and just asks—

JP: I had the trumpet — you always walked around with your trumpet case you know. "You working Saturday night?" I says, "No." He says, "You want to work?" "Yeah." "Well do you know Brooklyn at all?" I says, "Well I'll find it, don't worry, tell me what." So he told me what the name of the place and how to get there, what trains to take you know, and I wrote things down, and I went there and I played that Saturday night. Well evidently they liked my playing because they took my name and phone number and said, "You want to work next Saturday?" I said, "Well I'll see you Wednesday, and I'll let you know, because I think I have something else I might have promised and I don't want to" which I hadn't. But I didn't want to get into a steady Saturday night thing there, then I wouldn't be free, you know what I mean? I still wanted to be available, that was the thing, was to be available for a better thing.

MR: Because a job like that that you played with this guy, how much would that pay?

JP: Oh at that time, gee, I think about eighteen dollars.

MR: In New York City.

JP: Yeah fifteen dollars maybe. If you got twenty like that was good. And twenty five was better, and thirty, wow — that was a wow, thirty. Oh boy. So the whole thing was I was

on transfer then, so I couldn't work a steady job in the first three months. You couldn't work a steady job, even if it was offered.

MR: You had to go through that whole thing again, coming back to New York?

JP: Oh, yeah. But after three months I could accept a job, if I got one, with permission, a steady job.

MR: Permission from the union rep or whatever?

JP: The union, yeah. Because it would be a union job, and your name would go into the records and so forth and so on. Anyway, the day I got my card, there was a band that I was rehearsing with. It was what they call a rehearsal band. Musicians came in from out of town, and then somebody heard them and they went with a band on the road, or things, it was one of those kind of bands. Brick Fleegle. And I was in that band and George Wettling heard me. And he says, "You know Red Norvo and Mildred Bailey?" And I said, "Well I heard of them." He says, "You available?" I says, "Yeah." He says, "Why don't you make a rehearsal at Carnegie Hall, somewhere around that studio." And he says, "Will you be there?" And I says, "Yeah." He says, "All right, then I won't look for anybody else." So I went there and there was Red Norvo and Mildred Bailey and I sat down and there was Zeke Zarchy playing first trumpet, and Barney Zudekoff was Moe Zudekoff's brother. So there was Zeke Zarchy playing lead, I played second in the hot chair, and Barney Zudicoff played third trumpet. Those were the three trumpets. Wow. Good band too.

MR: Those were the days, huh?

JP: Oh, yeah, those were the days.

MR: And how long did you stay in New York?

JP: Well the band broke up at The Famous Door. We went to The Famous Door and it was around Christmas time — what a time to be let go, right? And the two bosses, Mutt and Jeff we called them because one was a big guy and the other one was shorty. They decided they couldn't afford to have the band during the Christmas holidays. So they let the band, the big band go, and they just kept Red Norvo and Mildred Bailey, and three other musicians. And John Kirby's quintet was the alternate band. So that was it. So there I was out of work right? So then incidentally, going in and out of the subway, Jerry Jerome and make the Harry James rehearsal which I did, and from there it was pretty good.

MR: Well in addition to all this big band playing, I know you've done a lot of small group things back in Rome? You've done your share of circus music, which is pretty strenuous, isn't it?

JP: Yeah, with Paul Navalle.

[off camera, Jack Palmer Jr.: Paul Navalle died.]

JP: Oh, did he? Oh wow. That's so sad.

MR: That's hard work, isn't it?

JP: What?

MR: Playing in the circus?

JP: Circus music is yeah, it's hard work because it never stops. You know, until the elephant breaks wind, or drops a giant—

MR: Now did it ever happen to you when the animals are walking by the band?

JP: Oh are you kidding? Jesus. I was playing and these lions used to go by and one of them always lifted up his leg — good thing we had a railing, you know a board thing there. This one always, in front of the band, and he waited until he got near the trumpet section. I couldn't stand that lion. He didn't like trumpet players.

MR: Oh, man, you should have got extra pay for that.

JP: Oh dear Lord.

MR: Did you ever see any like accidents in your circus times? Any bad things ever happen?

JP: No, I don't recall any.

MR: That's good.

JP: It was exciting though I mean, you know, all the aerialists and you know, there was always — circus music was always loud, furious, fast, and then there were waltzes. Never any — usually it was a waltz if it was anything slow.

MR: Fascinating.

JP: Yeah. I have to laugh at the elephants. Wow.

MR: When you go to pick out, if you could go and pick out any kind of record these days to listen to.

JP: A record?

MR: A record to listen to. What do you like to listen to now?

JP: Well I always liked big bands you know, to listen to. Woody Herman for instance, I enjoy his band. Any big band of that type. And small bands like John Kirby. Whatever small bands there were then. John Kirby had the smallest big band in the world.

MR: Benny Goodman had a small group in and out.

JP: Well he had a trio, he had a quartet, and he had the sextet. The trio was himself, the piano player and Gene Krupa. In the quartet he added Lionel Hampton. And in the sextet I think he added Georgie Auld on saxophone and Cootie Williams on trumpet. Anyway it went on and so forth.

MR: Did you ever have any dealings with Benny Goodman?

JP: No. Outside of being friendly, very dear friends with Vido Musso, who was in the band, so I would get to watch the rehearsals. Benny, I'd say, "Hello Benny." And he'd say, [grunts] "Hey." You know. He was very vocal — he was a grunter.

MR: Vido Musso was quite a character, wasn't he?

JP: Oh, yeah. We were close buddies. Vido was a funny guy, without trying to be funny. He had a natural sense of humor and with his lack of the English language, he had a style all his own, Vido. He was a character. He was a beautiful character.

MR: Mostly played by ear, didn't he?

JP: Well he was a slow reader. But so was Charlie Ventura. But where Charlie knew his chords because of his knowledge of the guitar, Vido didn't. Vido depended on his ear. Vido didn't have any chord knowledge. But see Charlie Ventura did. Bobby Hackett did. They were former guitar players. That's why they could play so beautifully and constructed choruses.

MR: Now before we quit we've got to talk about The Jackie Gleason Show a little bit.

JP: Sammy Spear.

MR: Yeah.

JP: And Ray Block. Sammy and I were great friends anyway so.

MR: How did that theme song go? The Jackie Gleason theme song?

JP: Gee what was it. I forgot what it was.

[humming]

JP: Well Gleason had a good ear for music. And of course when he was big enough to have writers, he would think of something, he would hum something, maybe a couple of bars. [humms] and they would have to write a whole thing on it, you know, but with that as the theme. But he was very musical, Gleason. In Newark, when we were in Newark, he wanted, he loved to play the trumpet you know, but he couldn't do it. He could blow good, he had natural chops. So I went with him in Newark. He says, "Let's go into town, I've got to buy a horn." So we went and I picked out a horn — fifteen dollars. Then he drove everybody crazy at the place. Then he used to call me out. He used to be on the floor and he'd say, "Come on out and we'll play," because I showed him how to play "I Love You Truly," which was first valve and open, it was easy, just eight bars. And he called me out on the floor and he'd take the trumpet and make a big deal about wiping his lips and chops and putting them together and that. And so then he played the first eight bars, which is all he knew, and I'd play the harmony to it.

MR: So it made him sound almost like he could play, right?

JP: Yeah. After eight bars then he says, "Well now we go for the big one," and he wipes his lip and everything, then he goes powwww, and then I'd top him, then he'd try to go higher, and I'd top him and then he'd go higher, 'till finally he says, "This last note is the one I grab toilet paper on" something to that effect you know. "This last note is where I go and get the bathroom paper out," and he'd make a big thing on that.

MR: How high was it?

JP: Oh, it was just up—

MR: Yeah, it wasn't even a note.

JP: No, no. But he had natural good chops, he did have.

MR: Now that show, The Jackie Gleason Show, was done live, wasn't it?

JP: Yeah.

MR: The TV thing was done live, so you had to be right on, no mistakes, or as few as possible.

JP: No we were on, right from the beginning, boom, that was it. Like we rehearsed before in front, and then we'd take a break, that's where we always ran across the alley to the saloon, Joe Harbor's Spotlight, we went over there and grabbed a few belts, then ran back, and we were all set to record or to do the show, whichever we were doing. They always recorded the show anyway. Wow. There always had to be a bar across the street, of any place we played, there had to be a bar. In the dead of winter, right? No you couldn't go get your coat or anything, zoom.

MR: Had to get your nourishment.

JP: Yeah. Oh, boy. One guy was smart, like leaders didn't care for that style, like if you carried a pint in a case you know what I mean? But they'd be secretive about it, like take it out of the case and go to the men's room. Glug-glug-glug — all secret style. I was wondering what this cord was.

MR: That's so we don't miss a word. Well this has been a fascinating time, Jack.

JP: Well thank you. Thank you for asking me. It is very refreshing for me, like to reminisce a little bit.

MR: And I learned yesterday that Jackie Gleason is your son's Godfather?

JP: Yeah. Well I stood up for Gleason's wedding, this is how that happened. And then he and Genevieve christened my son. Genevieve was Gleason's wife.

MR: Were you able over the years to keep track of how many records you played on?

JP: No. Hardly anybody does. You know like professional musicians, when I say that I mean like people that played music for a living, you moved around too much to collect records, then you had to move them around, you know what I mean? Unless like some guys had homes in New York or Queens, then they could start a collection, because when they left to go on the road, they had a place. But if you were moving around in hotels, you couldn't carry that stuff around.

MR: Plus I suppose sometimes you weren't even sure that the thing was going to end up as a record. You were just recording—

JP: No, no, no. When we were recording, we were recording to make records, oh yeah. It was a recording set and we got paid for a record date. That's what they called it, a record date. When they recorded us live, like from a hotel where we were broadcasting, they took that

off the air, but somehow they had to get permission to do it or something. There was pretty tight laws.

MR: Do you still get any royalties or any payments for all those years?

JP: No. Because the only one that got royalties was the leader. The sidemen, when I say sidemen, the musicians, we got paid for the date and that was it. The only one that signed a contract with the recording company was the leader, or the manager or whatever. But the leader always collected royalties. And they were very good about mailing his checks to him, you know.

MR: Well thanks for coming out here today.

JP: Gee, I sure enjoyed it.

MR: And we may have to do round two.

JP: Oh really? I enjoyed it very much. It's good to reminisce when somebody can prompt you, and you did great. You sure made me bring out some memories.

MR: Well good. You know you come from an area, Central New York, actually a lot of good musicians came out of here.

JP: Oh, yeah. How about the Zitos?

MR: The Zitos, and Montalbanos, and lots of Italians, lots of Italian names.

JP: Chic Esposito, Harry Esposito.

MR: A whole line of them.

JP: Rocky Carruccio, Rocky Cole, piano, Charlie French, Art French. Well there were a lot of good musicians out of this area. Tony Johnson, Tony Ginsanti, he went with Horace Hite, and then with Frankie Carle, when Frankie Carle left Horace Heidt, he went with him. And Rocky Carruccio or Rocky Cole was the piano player, went with Patti Page, he stayed with her for years.

MR: Well great. We're going to wrap up here, and let our cameraman go home.

JP: Well thank you very much for having me.

MR: Thank you. It's a great pleasure.

JP: My pleasure.

MR: All right.

JP: Great.